

Sarcophilus harrisii

Tasmanian devil



Length 22½–26⅞ in
(57–65.5 cm)

Tail 9½–10 in
(24–26 cm)

Weight 11–31 lb
(5–14 kg)

Location Tasmania

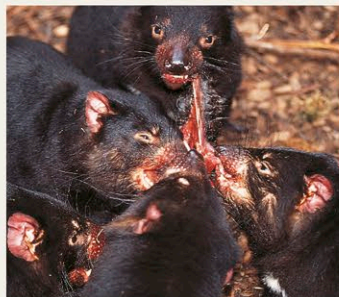
Social unit Individual

Status Endangered



The largest marsupial carnivore, it hunts prey of varied sizes and also scavenges. Nocturnal, it screeches and rears up if alarmed. It makes its den in a burrow or among rocks. Born after a gestation of 30–31 days, the young attach to the female's 4 teats in her shallow, rear-opening pouch. Facial tumor disease has caused an 80 percent decline in its population in less than 20 years. However, in a few places, some groups have become resistant to the disease.

COMPETING AT A KILL



The Tasmanian devil is normally solitary, but its excellent sense of smell leads to many converging on a large carcass. Its powerful jaws and sharp, sturdy teeth rip up the hide and crush gristle and bone. The devils growl and snarl at each other for the prime parts, but stop short of physical clashes.

WHITE ON BLACK
The devil has long, white patches on its chest and rump.

*Myrmecobius fasciatus*

Numbat



Length 8–11 in
(20–28 cm)

Tail 6½–8½ in
(16–21 cm)

Weight 11–26 oz
(300–725 g)

Location S.W. Australia

Social unit Individual

Status Endangered



The numbat, or banded anteater, has a long (4 in/10 cm) tongue to lick up termites, or very rarely ants, after it has ripped open the nest using the large-clawed, powerful forefeet. They have 50–52 teeth—more than any other land mammal—even though they are small and poorly developed. Day-active and solitary, the numbat chases same-sex intruders from its territory. Offspring attach to the female's 4 teats for 4 months, then are suckled in the nest for a further 2–3 months.

*Perameles gunnii*

Eastern barred bandicoot



Length 10½–14 in
(27–35 cm)

Tail 2¼–4¼ in
(7–11 cm)

Weight 1–3¼ lb
(0.5–1.5 kg)

Location S.E. Australia, Tasmania

Social unit Individual

Status Vulnerable



A few hundred of these bandicoots survive in mainland Australia, in Victoria, the majority being found in Tasmania. This omnivorous opportunist forages alone at night and shelters by day in a simple nest of grasses, leaves, and twigs. The eastern barred bandicoot has rabbitlike ears, 3–4 whitish back stripes, and a white tail. Its life cycle is rapid: 13-day gestation, weaning by 60 days. Females are sexually mature at age 3 months, males at 4–5 months.

Echymipera kalubu

Common echymipera



Length 9⅞–15 in
(22.5–38 cm)

Tail 2¼–4 in
(6–10 cm)

Weight ⅞–3⅛ lb
(0.4–1.8 kg)

Location New Guinea and surrounding islands

Social unit Individual

Status Least concern



Bandicoots are mostly insectivorous, rat- to rabbit-sized marsupials. The common echymipera has a long, mobile snout, an outer coat of stiff, stout hairs in shades of brown, copper, yellow, and black, buff underparts, and a hairless tail. It forages alone at night for prey, takes fruits, berries, and other plant matter, and aggressively repels others of its kind. It shelters by day in a hollow log, leaf pile, or self-dug burrow.

*Macrotis lagotis*

Greater bilby



Length 12–22 in
(30–55 cm)

Tail 8–11½ in
(20–29 cm)

Weight 2¼–5½ lb
(1–2.5 kg)

Location W. and C. Australia

Social unit Pair

Status Vulnerable



Also known as the rabbit-eared bandicoot, this omnivorous species is recognized by its huge ears, long hind feet, and tricolored tail: blue-gray at the base (as on the body), then black, with the last half white and feathery. It digs powerfully to shelter by day in a burrow 10 ft (3 m) long and some 7 ft (2 m) deep. Pairs associate for the breeding season and the 1–3 offspring, born after 13–16 days' gestation, leave the pouch after 75–80 days.

Notoryctes typhlops

Southern marsupial mole



Length 3¼–3¾ in
(8.5–9.5 cm)

Tail ⅞–⅝ in
(1.6–1.8 cm)

Weight 1⅞–1¾ oz
(30–50 g)

Location N., N.W., and S. Australia

Social unit Individual

Status Least concern

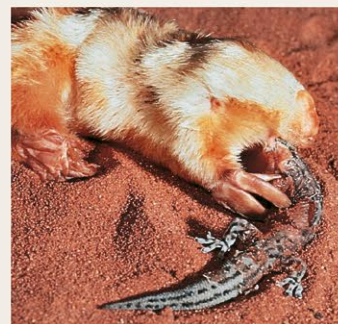


The southern marsupial mole tunnels down to 8 ft (2.5 m) in sandy deserts, loose-soiled grassland, and scrubby bush. It "swims" through light sand, which collapses behind leaving no permanent tunnel. Food includes fungi and tubers as well as animal prey, which is eaten whenever encountered. The silky, off-white to cinnamon fur is rubbed shiny by burrowing, and may be stained deep red by iron minerals in the soil. The female's pouch, in which she carries 1–2 young, opens rearward so it does not fill with soil.

BURROWING MACHINE

Sand and soil are probed by the horny nose pad, scooped aside by the front feet, and kicked up and back by the 3 large claws on each rear foot.

MOLE FOOD



The southern marsupial mole eats soil-dwelling worms, grubs, centipedes, and even small lizards, such as the gecko held here by the huge front claws. Using smell and touch, it follows small tunnels made by potential prey in order to catch its victims. It may forage on the surface after rain.



twin, spadelike front claws